Case interview starter sheet

The shape of a case interview on one sheet, with the profitability tree and a closing template.

The four parts of a case

1. **Clarify**
   Play the question back. Ask about the goal, the timeline and anything you do not understand.
2. **Structure**
   Take a minute. Lay out three or four areas to explore that do not overlap and together cover the problem.
3. **Analyse**
   Go where the data points. Say each calculation out loud and say what each number means.
4. **Recommend**
   Lead with the answer, give two or three reasons, then the risks and next steps.

Profitability: where to look

Area	Questions to ask
Revenue = price × volume	Did prices fall? Did we sell fewer units? Did the mix of products or customers change?
Costs = fixed + variable	Which cost line grew fastest? Is it one-off or lasting? How do we compare with competitors?
Outside the company	Is the whole market shrinking? Did a competitor, regulation or customer need change?

Market entry: where to look

Area	Questions to ask
The market	How big is it, how fast is it growing, and how profitable are the players in it?
Competition	Who leads, and why? What would make customers switch?
Our company	Which strengths carry over? What would it cost to enter, and how long until we break even?
How to enter	Build, buy or partner? What could go wrong?

Closing template

“My recommendation is to ___ because ___ and ___. The main risk is ___, so as next steps I would ___.”

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